



Everyone in the coastal village of Geilpur smells of fish, someone observes in the new Bengali series *Mandaar* (streaming on Hoichoi). "And I'm a cat. Meow!" replies a newly-arrived cop named Mukaddar, speaking in effete-sounding English. In another scene, he liberally pours ketchup over the catfish on his plate, a culinary travesty.

On the face of it, such moments don't belong in a *Macbeth* adaptation, but then those fish do appear to be "steeped in blood", and Mukaddar (played by director Anirban Bhattacharya) is a stand-in for Shakespeare's Macduff—a much more corrupt version. *Mandaar* nicely recasts the play's characters. Mandaar/ Macbeth (Debasish Mondal) is a strongman who works for a local leader, and whose impotence is a source of frustration for his wife, the sensuous Laili (Sohini Sarkar), obsessed with having a child.

After setting things up with a striking version of the "Fair is foul and foul is fair" in the opening, this five-episode series meanders for a while but soon builds in intensity with some powerful scenes such as one where Mandaar, beset by ghostly visions, pursues Pedo, the weird, supple young boy who is one of the "witches". Or a nightmare shot in desaturated colours, emphasising the redness of the characters' clothes while rendering much else monochrome.

More than any of Shakespeare's other works, "the Scottish Play" (as it is sometimes called for

CINEMA/ OTT

THERE IS ALWAYS BLOOD

Shakespeare's *Macbeth* has been brought to the screen in many shapes and languages. Now we have a playfully intense Bengali web series and an austere American film

